

# Idioms database

**a drop in the ocean** a very small amount that will not have much effect: *The cost of a hotel for one night is a drop in the ocean for a big company like that.*

**a home from home** a place where you feel as relaxed as you do in your own home: *Everyone knows me at this hotel so it's a real home from home.*

**a leopard can't change its spots** used for saying that someone will never change their behaviour or character: *Jimmy says he's changed, but a leopard can't change its spots, you know.*

**a sight for sore eyes** someone or something that you are very pleased to see: *You're a sight for sore eyes! Thank goodness you're here!*

**a stitch in time (saves nine)** used for saying that it is better to solve a problem now, rather than leave it until later when it may be more difficult to deal with: *If there's a problem with your car, it's better to get it looked at now. You know what they say: 'a stitch in time ...'.*

**a stone's throw (away/from)** very close (to): *Where we live is only a stone's throw from the park.*

**Achilles' heel** a weak feature of someone or something that could cause failure or be attacked: *She's an extremely talented politician, but her Achilles' heel may be her inability to prioritise.*

**add fuel to the fire** make a bad situation worse: *Your refusing to discuss this with Colin is just adding fuel to the fire, in my opinion.*

**all in good time** used for telling someone to wait for something and not try to make you hurry: *You'll get the report when it's finished. All in good time!*

**all mod cons** all modern conveniences, the machines and pieces of equipment in your house that make life easy and comfortable: *I'd quite like to move to a place that has all mod cons.*

**an act of God** an event such as a flood, lightning or an earthquake that is produced by natural forces, and that people have no control over: *The insurance doesn't cover acts of God.*

**as the crow flies** in a straight line (used for measuring distance): *It's about 200 miles as the crow flies.*

**at a loose end** with nothing in particular to do: *If you're at a loose end this weekend, why don't we get together?*

**at the drop of a hat** immediately or in a way that shows that you have no doubts about doing something: *Let me know if you need help and I'll be there at the drop of a hat!*

**be born with a silver spoon in your mouth** have advantages because you come from a rich family: *I've always had to work hard because I wasn't born with a silver spoon in my mouth.*

**be on the same wavelength** understand the way another person thinks because you often have the same ideas and opinions they do: *It was a difficult meeting because David and I didn't seem to be on the same wavelength.*

**before your time** used for saying that something happened or existed before you were born or before you lived or worked somewhere: *When I was a girl, we didn't have mobile phones. That was before your time, of course.*

**below/under par** below the usual or expected standard: *Your essays have been a bit below par recently. Is anything wrong?*

**big mouth** used as a criticism of someone when they say things they should not: *Don't tell Jamie anything you want to remain secret – he's got a big mouth!*

**blot on the landscape** something that makes a place look less attractive, for example an ugly building: *Many people in the town think that the old factory is a blot on the landscape.*

**break even** if a person or business breaks even, they neither make a profit nor lose money: *We didn't make a profit last year, but we did break even.*

**break the mould** change a situation by doing something that is very different from what most people usually do or have done in the past: *I thought her last movie really broke the mould.*

**bury your head in the sand** ignore a problem or an unpleasant situation and hope that it will disappear: *We shouldn't just bury our heads in the sand and hope that this problem goes away.*

**change your tune** change your opinion or attitude: *Tom often criticised Nadia until he met her, but now he's changed his tune.*

**clean as a whistle** completely honest or legal: *I'm not worried about the tax inspection. This company's accounts are clean as a whistle.*

**clean as a whistle** extremely clean: *My mum's coming to visit tomorrow so I want the house to be as clean as a whistle when she gets here.*

**come clean (about sth)** tell the truth about something that you have kept secret: *You'd better come clean and tell Mum it was you who broke the flowerpot.*

**come rain or shine** used for saying that something always happens or someone always does something despite bad weather or difficult conditions: *I'm determined to finish building the house by the end of the month, come rain or shine.*

**commuter belt** area surrounding a large city where many people who work in that city live: *Towns in the commuter belt often seem to lack character.*

**concrete jungle** unpleasant part of a city where there are a lot of ugly buildings close together: *Where we used to live was a bit of a concrete jungle.*

**couch potato** someone who spends a lot of time sitting at home watching television: *I've become a bit of a couch potato since I stopped playing football.*

**cry over spilt milk** waste time feeling upset about something bad that has happened and cannot be changed: *I know your CD player's broken, but there's no point crying over spilt milk, is there?*

**do sth on a whim** do because of a sudden feeling that you must have or do something: *Wendy decided on a whim to redecorate the whole house.*

**down on your luck** having a long period of difficulty finding work and earning money: *The man was obviously down on his luck, so I gave him a little money.*

**draw the line (at)** say that you will definitely not allow or accept something: *I don't mind you asking if you can borrow some money, but I draw the line at you taking it out of my purse without asking first.*

**draw the short straw** be chosen to do something unpleasant: *Somebody has to stay home to look after the dog, and I'm afraid you've drawn the short straw.*

**fall short** not reach a particular level or to fail to achieve something you were trying to do: *We tried to raise 1,000 euros for charity, but we fell short by about 50 euros.*

**fifty-fifty** equal, or into two equal parts: *We split the cost of the meal fifty-fifty.*

**fly off the handle** suddenly become extremely angry without a good reason: *Whatever she says, don't fly off the handle. Stay calm!*

**follow your nose** do what you feel is right in a particular situation, although you are not certain: *The detective had learned to follow his nose in situations like this.*

**follow your nose** go straight forward, without turning: *Once you go past the traffic lights, just follow your nose.*

**for good** permanently, without the possibility of change in the future: *Have Don and Jenny split up for good, do you think, or is it only temporary?*

**for the time being** for now: *I'm staying in rented accommodation for the time being, but hope to buy a place early next year.*

**from time to time** sometimes, but not often: *We see Brian from time to time, but not regularly.*

**gain/get/have/take the upper hand** gain/get/have/take control or advantage over a person or situation: *It looked like Ivor was going to win the game, but I soon got the upper hand.*

**get on like a house on fire** become good friends very quickly and have a lot to talk to each other about: *George and Isabelle seem to be getting on like a house on fire, don't they?*

**get sth off your chest** talk to someone about something that has been worrying you, so that you feel better about it: *It feels such a relief to have got this off my chest.*

**get the wrong end of the stick** understand something completely wrongly: *Don said he was going to France and I got the wrong end of the stick and thought he was moving there for ever.*

**get/catch sb's drift** understand the basic meaning: *Doreen and I have been having some problems recently, if you catch my drift.*

**get/have your way** be allowed to have or do what you want: *If I had my way, I would stay at home this summer.*

**give sb a taste/dose of their own medicine** treat someone in the same bad way they treat other people: *He got me into trouble, so I'm going to give him a taste of his own medicine!*

**give sb your word** promise to do something: *I give you my word I won't tell anyone.*

**give sth a miss** decide not to do something that you usually do: *I think I'll give the office party a miss this year.*

**go halves** share the cost of something with someone so that you each pay 50%: *Let's go halves on the meal, shall we?*

**go to your head** if success goes to your head, it makes you think that you are better or more important than you really are: *I hope getting that scholarship doesn't go to Carol's head.*

**grin and bear it** accept a difficult situation without complaining or showing how you feel: *An author just has to grin and bear it when a book gets a bad review.*

**have a change of heart** change your opinion about something or decide not to do something you were planning to do: *William's had a change of heart and decided not to go to university after all.*

**have green fingers** be good at growing plants: *My wife's always had green fingers, whereas I don't know anything about growing plants.*

**have time on your hands** have more time available than you need: *Julie has a lot more time on her hands now that her children have all left home.*

**have your wits about you** be able to think quickly and make sensible decisions: *You've got to have your wits about you when dealing with pushy salespeople.*

**(hear sth) on/through the grapevine** the way in which information spreads quickly from one person to another through conversation: *I heard through the grapevine you might be getting married soon.*

**home sweet home** used for saying that you are happy to be back in your own home: *It was a good trip, but there's nothing like home sweet home.*

**in/for donkey's years** an extremely long time: *I haven't been swimming in donkey's years.*

**in sb's bad/good books** used for saying that someone is annoyed/pleased with you: *I don't think I'm in Mrs Patterson's good books at the moment.*

**in the dark (about)** not knowing very much about something, because other people are keeping it secret from you: *The Prime Minister kept even his closest colleagues in the dark about when he would call a general election.*

**in the middle of nowhere** a long way from any town or city: *The car broke down and we realised we were in the middle of nowhere.*

**in the nick of time** just in time to prevent something bad happening: *The swimmers were rescued in the nick of time.*

**in the sticks** in an area far from the town or city: *I don't think I could live so far out in the sticks.*

**it's as broad as it's long** used for saying that you cannot choose between two things or actions because they are equal: *It's as broad as it's long whether we get there on Saturday night or on Sunday morning.*

**keep a straight face** remain serious and not laugh: *I couldn't keep a straight face when I saw Mike's new haircut.*

**keep sb posted** regularly give someone information about something they are interested in, for example how a situation is changing or developing: *Do please keep me posted about any developments.*

**keep sth under your hat** keep something secret: *Keep it under your hat, but we're thinking of buying a new house.*

**keep up with the Joneses** try to be as rich, successful, etc as your neighbours: *I don't need a new car, and I'm really not interested in keeping up with the Joneses.*

**keep your hair on** used for telling someone not to get angry or upset: *Keep your hair on! There's no need to get annoyed!*

**kick yourself** be very annoyed because you have made a mistake, missed an opportunity, etc: *I could have kicked myself when I realised I'd left my wallet in the restaurant.*

**knee-high to a grasshopper** very small, because you were very young: *When I was kneehigh to a grasshopper, I used to believe that a monster lived under my bed.*

**know sth inside out** be very familiar with: *Maria's been in the business for years and she knows advertising inside out.*

**know what's what** know the important facts about a situation: *Ask Tony about the proposed changes. He knows what's what.*

**last word** in the newest and best type of something: *The ZD-2000 is the last word in mobile phones.*

**lay/put your cards on the table** tell people exactly what you are thinking or what you are intending to do: *I'm going to lay my cards on the table and offer you an extra £1,000. But that's my final offer!*

**let nature take its course** allow something to develop without trying to influence it: *I'm sure sales will improve if we just let nature take its course.*

**let off steam** shout or do something that allows you to get rid of anger: *I was so annoyed I had to go for a long walk to let off steam.*

**let sleeping dogs lie** leave a person or situation alone if they might cause you trouble: *I know you think your parents are being unfair, but it's probably best to let sleeping dogs lie and not make it worse by arguing.*

**let your hair down** relax and enjoy yourself because you are in a comfortable environment: *It's good to let your hair down after a hard week at work.*

**life and soul of the party** someone who is very lively at social events: *Harry's so much fun and everyone says he's the life and soul of the party.*

**like two peas in a pod** used for saying that two people look, behave or think exactly the same: *Irene and her sister are like two peas in a pod.*

**line your pocket(s)** obtain money, especially by acting dishonestly: *He'd been lining his pockets for years before he was finally caught.*

**live and let live** used for saying that you should accept other people's beliefs and way of life, even if they are very different from your own: *I don't agree with what he's doing, but live and let live, I say.*

**lock, stock and barrel** including every part of a particular thing, situation, place, etc: *They've sold all their possessions, lock, stock and barrel.*

**lose your bearings** become confused about where you are and where other things are: *I lost my bearings for a moment, but then realised where I was.*

**make a beeline for** go towards someone or something in the quickest and most direct way: *As soon as we arrived at the hotel, Molly made a beeline for the manager to complain.*

**make yourself at home** feel relaxed and behave in the same way as you do in your own home: *Charles will be down in a moment, so please make yourselves at home.*

**never/don't look a gift horse in the mouth** if you are given something good, you should not complain about it or try to find things that are wrong with it: *The flat wasn't in very good condition, but we were staying there rent-free, and you should never look a gift horse in the mouth, should you?*

**no rhyme or reason** used for emphasising that there is no reason or explanation for something: *There seems to be no rhyme or reason for the decision.*

**not have a leg to stand on** not have any way of proving that you are right about something: *George tried to argue that the world was flat, but of course he didn't have a leg to stand on.*

**not see the wood for the trees** used for saying that someone cannot understand what is important in a situation because they are thinking too much about small details: *Many people can't see the wood for the trees when talking about joining the eurozone; they just think about what's on the notes and coins and don't think about the economic benefits.*

**off the beaten track** away from populated areas or areas popular with tourists: *We like to get off the beaten track when we go on holiday.*

**on good terms (with)** have a good relationship with someone: *When I left the job, I was still on good terms with everyone in the office.*

**on the spur of the moment** if you do something on the spur of the moment, you do it suddenly and do not take time to plan it or think carefully about it: *We booked the holiday on the spur of the moment. We hadn't been planning to take a break at all this summer.*

**on the street** with no place to live: *Life is hard on the street.*

**on the town** spending the evening enjoying yourself in bars, clubs, theatres, etc: *Did you go out on the town on your birthday?*

**once in a blue moon** very rarely: *To be honest, I only go to museums once in a blue moon. I just don't have time usually.*

**out of the blue** happening in a way that is sudden and unexpected, and does not seem connected with anything that happened before: *Then, suddenly, out of the blue, she said she wanted a divorce.*

**out of this world** extremely good or impressive: *The food at that restaurant is out of this world!*

**over the top** more than what is considered normal or suitable: *Don't you think spending 500 euros on a pair of shoes was a bit over the top?*

**pride of place** in the place that is most central or important: *This stamp's extremely rare, and takes pride of place in my stamp collection.*

**pull (a few) strings** use your influence in order to get something you want or to help someone, especially when this is unfair: *I don't think it's fair to pull strings in order to get a job.*

**put sth in perspective** provide a sensible way of judging how good, bad, important, etc something is in comparison with other things: *My illness has certainly put everything else in perspective.*

**put two and two together** guess what is happening or what something means based on what you have seen or heard: *He didn't tell us he was retiring, but we could all put two and two together.*

**put your feet up** sit down and relax, especially with your feet raised off the ground: *Put your feet up and I'll make dinner.*

**quick/slow on the uptake** taking a very short/long time to understand or realise something: *I'm sure Chad understood what you were suggesting; he's very quick on the uptake.*

**recharge your batteries** rest after being very busy, so that you will be ready to start working again: *Why don't you take a week off work to recharge your batteries?*

**red tape** documents, rules or processes that cause delays: *Is there a lot of red tape involved in getting a passport?*

**reinvent the wheel** waste time and effort trying to do something that someone else has already done well: *Just use the same document you used last time, because there's no point reinventing the wheel.*

**ring a bell** something that rings a bell sounds familiar to you, although you cannot remember the exact details: *The name rings a bell but I'm not sure if I've ever met her.*

**round the bend** crazy: *That noise is driving me round the bend!*

**satellite town** town or city that is close to and depends on a larger city: *Brentwood is a satellite town just outside London.*

**sb is only human** used for saying someone has been weak in the ways most people are weak and should not be blamed for their behaviour: *I'm sorry I made a mistake, but I'm only human.*

**see eye to eye (with sb)** agree with someone or have the same opinion as them: *Imogen and I have never really seen eye to eye.*

**set your heart on** decide that you want something very much: *I had set my heart on getting married on the beach, but the bad weather meant we couldn't.*

**six of one (and) half a dozen of the other** used for saying that two things are equally good or bad: *We could get there on Saturday night or Sunday morning; it's six of one and half a dozen of the other, really.*

**speak volumes** provide a lot of information, especially in an indirect way: *What he said to Mandy speaks volumes about the way he treats his staff.*

**split hairs** argue or worry about very small details or differences that are not important: *Whether you call them 'terrorists' or 'freedom fighters' is just splitting hairs – the point is that they're killing people!*

**steal the show** receive a lot of attention because you give the best performance in a show or other event: *There was one comedian who really stole the show. She was fantastic!*

**stick to your guns** refuse to change what you are saying or doing despite the opposition or criticism of other people: *I admire Kelly for the way she always sticks to her guns.*

**stop dead in your tracks** suddenly stop, for example because you are surprised: *When I heard the gunshot, I stopped dead in my tracks.*

**take a short cut to** follow a path that is quicker and shorter than the usual way: *I walked to school and I used to take a short cut along the canal.*

**take stock (of)** spend some time thinking about the situation you are in before you decide what to do next: *Let's take a couple of days to take stock of the situation and then we'll make a decision.*

**take the law into your own hands** punish someone in your own way without involving the police or the courts, often by doing something illegal yourself: *I know you're angry, but that's no reason to take the law into your own hands.*

**take the scenic route** follow a longer path than the usual one because it is more attractive: *We're not lost – we're just taking the scenic route.*

**tell tales** tell someone in authority about bad things that someone else has done, because you want them to be punished: *Toby, stop telling tales about your classmates.*

**the edge over** an advantage that makes someone or something more successful than other people or things: *Our product's got the edge over the competition because it's so lightweight.*

**the luck of the draw** used for saying people have limited control over what life brings them: *I never wanted to become a butcher, but I guess that's the luck of the draw.*

**the other day** recently: *There was an interesting item on the news the other day.*

**the powers that be** the people who control a situation: *I don't know if the powers that be will agree to that.*

**the tools of the trade** the skills and equipment that you need in order to do your job: *A good bedside manner is one of the tools of the trade for a doctor.*

**throw the book at sb** punish someone very severely: *They'll really throw the book at him this time.*

**tidy sum/amount** large sum/amount: *I've managed to put away a tidy sum this year.*

**touch wood** used when you have said that you have had good luck in order to prevent bad luck from happening to you: *I'll find a new job before too long, touch wood.*

**turn over a new leaf** change your life by starting to be a better person or stopping a bad habit: *Ralph seems to have turned over a new leaf this term.*

**under sb's thumb** completely controlled by someone else: *I became self-employed because I was sick of being under someone's thumb.*

**up in arms about** angry and complaining about something: *Everyone in the office is up in arms about having to work next weekend.*

**variety is the spice of life** used for saying that different experiences and situations make life enjoyable or interesting: *I do a million different things at work, but I suppose variety is the spice of life.*

**your flesh and blood** your relative: *My family is very important to me because, after all, they're my flesh and blood.*